EAST WEST UNIVERSITY

ENG 102

Term paper on

Revisiting the Hundred Acre Wood:

A Psychological Disorder Analysis of Disney's Christopher Robin

Submitted by :

Mumtahina Mubassira Rahman

Zahedul Islam

Tasmia Adri

Student's ID :

2024-3-60-559

2024-3-60-561

2024-3-60-558

Section : 37

Submitted to : Ms. Pragna Laboni

Date of submission : 20 May , 2025

Contents

i. Cover Page----------i
ii. Index----------ii-iii
iii. Introduction----------1
iv. Character Analysis----------1-2
v. Symbolism & Mental Health Themes----------2
vi. Critical Reviews & Psychological Themes----------3
vii. Opinion from Articles----------4
viii. Reflection of Authors----------4
ix. Conclusion----------5
x. References----------5
xi. Appendix----------6

Contribution

Student ID	Name	Covered Content
2024-3-60-559	Mumtahina Mubassira	Introduction, Character Analysis, Symbolism & Mental Health Themes, References
2024-3-60-561	Zahedul Islam	Critical Reviews & Psychological Themes, Opinion from Articles, Reflection of Authors
2024-3-60-558	Tasmia Adri	Conclusion, Appendix

Introduction

Disney's *Christopher Robin* (2018) presents a touching narrative of an overworked man who rediscovers joy and purpose through an unexpected reunion with his childhood companions from the Hundred Acre Wood. While on the surface, it is a whimsical and nostalgic family film, deeper analysis reveals rich psychological subtext. Each character, particularly Christopher Robin himself, can be interpreted as representing various mental health challenges—from anxiety and depression to traits of ADHD and obsessive-compulsive tendencies. This paper explores these symbolic representations, emphasizing how the film subtly engages with complex psychological themes and the importance of reconnecting with one's inner child for emotional healing.[i]

Character Analysis

a. Christopher Robin – Depression, PTSD, and Burnout
As an adult, Christopher Robin is portrayed as emotionally withdrawn, overworked, and disconnected from his family. He shows symptoms of depression such as anhedonia (loss of pleasure), low mood, fatigue, and feelings of hopelessness. His military background hints at possible PTSD, reflected in his rigid demeanor and avoidance of emotions. [ii]Burnout, a condition related to chronic workplace stress, is also evident in his inability to balance personal and professional life. His emotional healing begins as he reconnects with his childhood memories and reclaims his inner joy.[iii]

b. Winnie the Pooh – OCD and Binge Eating Tendencies
Pooh is characterized by his obsessive focus on honey and repetitive behaviors. His routines, such as specific ways of thinking and speaking, may symbolically represent Obsessive-Compulsive Disorder. His persistent cravings and emotional reliance on food can also be interpreted as binge eating tendencies. However, Pooh remains optimistic and gentle, offering comfort to others.

c. Piglet – Generalized Anxiety Disorder (GAD)
Piglet constantly worries and anticipates danger, even in safe environments. His trembling voice, hesitance, and hypervigilance are indicative of Generalized Anxiety Disorder. Despite his fear, Piglet often shows courage, suggesting that anxiety does not negate bravery.

d. Eeyore – Major Depressive Disorder
Eeyore's gloomy outlook, lack of energy, and persistent negativity align with symptoms of Major Depressive Disorder. He often expresses a sense of worthlessness and pessimism, and while others offer him support, he remains largely unresponsive to positive stimuli.

e. Tigger – ADHD (Hyperactive-Impulsive Type)
Tigger is impulsive, hyperactive, and often acts without considering consequences. His restlessness and exuberance suggest Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder. Despite the chaos he sometimes causes, Tigger brings energy and spontaneity to the group.

f. Rabbit – Obsessive-Compulsive Personality Disorder (OCPD)
Rabbit's need for control, order, and perfectionism are hallmarks of OCPD. He becomes anxious when plans go awry and tries to manage others' behaviors. His rigidity contrasts with the spontaneity of other characters.

g. Owl – Narcissistic Personality Traits
Owl often presents himself as knowledgeable and superior, even when incorrect. His condescending tone and need for admiration suggest narcissistic traits. However, his intentions are usually well-meaning.

h. Kanga and Roo – Protective Parenting and Mild Spectrum Traits
Kanga demonstrates anxious attachment and overprotectiveness, which can be associated with parental anxiety. Roo, meanwhile, exhibits curiosity and routine-seeking, which can be interpreted as traits seen in Autism Spectrum Disorder, though mildly.

Symbolism & Mental Health Themes

The Hundred Acre Wood functions as more than a setting; it symbolizes Christopher Robin's inner world and the parts of himself he has neglected. Each character reflects a fragment of his emotional state, and their reunion represents a process of psychological reintegration.[iv]

The film promotes emotional healing through reconnection with one's inner child. As Christopher Robin rediscovers play, affection, and presence, his mental state improves. This metaphor supports the idea that acknowledging and nurturing one's inner vulnerabilities is key to overcoming psychological distress.

Critical Analysis

The film offers a gentle, accessible portrayal of mental health struggles. By personifying various psychological states through beloved characters, it fosters empathy and normalization. However, the symbolic nature of these portrayals means they lack clinical depth and may be overly simplified. Nevertheless, the film serves as a valuable conversation starter about emotional well-being, especially for younger audiences and families. It subtly encourages viewers to acknowledge stress, reconnect with joy, and seek support when overwhelmed.

Summary of making the movie

The world of *Winnie the Pooh* originated in the 1920s through the works of British author A.A. Milne, inspired by his son, Christopher Robin Milne. The stories feature anthropomorphic animals living in the Hundred Acre Wood, each with distinct personalities. Disney popularized these characters through animated adaptations, transforming them into global icons of childhood.[v]

Christopher Robin (2018), directed by Marc Forster, presents an original continuation of this world, focusing on an adult Christopher Robin who is burdened by work and responsibilities. The film blends live-action and CGI to bring beloved characters like Winnie the Pooh, Piglet, Eeyore, Tigger, and others to life in a post-war London setting.[vi]
Psychological disorders are defined in the Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, Fifth Edition (DSM-5), which categorizes mental health conditions based on symptoms, duration, and impact on functioning.[vii]Fictional characters often display behaviors that can symbolically align with these diagnoses. While these associations are not clinical, they offer insights into human psychology and can foster empathy and understanding.

Critical Reviews & Psychological Themes

The New Yorker – "The Moral Clarity of 'Christopher Robin'"
This review highlights the film's exploration of mindfulness and the human spirit. It discusses how Christopher Robin's reconnection with Pooh and friends serves as a metaphor for rediscovering life's simple pleasures amidst adult responsibilities.

Time – "'Christopher Robin' Is as Much a Movie For Adults as It Is For Kids"
Time's review emphasizes the film's appeal to adult audiences, focusing on themes of work-life balance, the loss of imagination, and the importance of slowing down to appreciate life's moments.

The Guardian – "Christopher Robin Review – Midlife-Crisis Drama or Children's Film?"
This article analyses the film's tone, questioning its target audience due to its exploration of adult themes like midlife crises and emotional detachment, juxtaposed with its child-friendly characters.

RogerEbert.com – "Christopher Robin" Review
The review critiques the film's handling of adult themes, particularly the depiction of Christopher Robin's struggle with work-induced stress and the neglect of his family, suggesting a commentary on the pressures of modern adulthood.

Business Insider – "'Christopher Robin' Is a Precious Delight of a Movie That Will Leave You Crying"
This review discusses the emotional depth of the film, noting its darker tones and the portrayal of Christopher Robin's journey from a joyless adult back to embracing his inner child.

Opinion from Articles

"Pathology in the Hundred Acre Wood" (2000)
Published in the *Canadian Medical Association Journal*, this satirical article examines the characters of the Hundred Acre Wood through a neurodevelopmental lens. While primarily focusing on characters like Pooh and Piglet, it also touches upon Christopher Robin's role in the narrative.

"The Lonely Boy: A Psychological Case Study of Christopher Robin"
This blog post delves into the idea that each character represents a facet of Christopher Robin's psyche, suggesting that the entire Hundred Acre Wood is a manifestation of his inner world [1]

"Winnie the Pooh Characters and Mental Illness"
An article that explores the potential mental health conditions represented by each character, offering insights into how these portrayals can reflect real-world psychological issues.

Reflection of Authors

Schizophrenia and Imaginary Companions
Several analyses suggest that Christopher Robin's vivid interactions with his stuffed animals could be indicative of schizophrenia. This perspective posits that the characters in the Hundred Acre Wood are manifestations of his imagination, reflecting a detachment from reality.

Dissociative Identity Disorder (DID)
An academic paper discusses the possibility that Christopher Robin exhibits signs of Dissociative Identity Disorder. In this view, each character represents a fragmented aspect of his psyche, serving as coping mechanisms for underlying trauma.

Autism Spectrum Disorder (ASD)
Some interpretations propose that Christopher Robin displays characteristics associated with Autism Spectrum Disorder, such as social isolation and intense focus on specific interests.

Separation Anxiety and Emotional Detachment
In the live-action film *Christopher Robin* (2018), the adult version of the character grapples with work-induced stress and emotional detachment from his family. This portrayal has been linked to themes of separation anxiety and the challenges of transitioning from childhood to adulthood.

[1] cartoonsforbreakfast.blogspot.com

Conclusion

Christopher Robin is more than a nostalgic revisiting of childhood; it is a psychologically rich narrative that explores the toll of adulthood and the healing power of emotional reconnection. Through symbolic representations of mental disorders, the film humanizes psychological struggles and advocates for analyzing *Christopher Robin* through this lens allows viewers to engage more deeply with its characters and messages. The Hundred Acre Wood becomes a metaphorical space representing aspects of Christopher Robin's psyche, making his journey not just physical but deeply emotional and psychological.[1]

References

[i] Forster, M. (Director). (2018). *Christopher Robin* [Film]. Walt Disney Pictures.

[ii] Milne, A. A. (1926). *Winnie-the-Pooh*. Methuen & Co.

[iii] Maté, G. (2009). *In the realm of hungry ghosts: Close encounters with addiction*. North Atlantic Books.

[iv] Burge, E. A., & Lee, C. M. (2016). The inner child and expressive therapy: Integrating symbolic characters for emotional healing. *Journal of Humanistic Counseling*, 55(1), 44–59.

[v] Shea, S. E., Gordon, K., Hawkins, A., Kawchuk, J., & Smith, D. (2000). Pathology in the Hundred Acre Wood: A neurodevelopmental perspective on A.A. Milne. *Canadian Medical Association Journal*, 163(12), 1557–1559.

[vi] Forster, M. (Director). (2018). *Christopher Robin* [Film]. Walt Disney Pictures.

[vii] American Psychiatric Association. (2013). *Diagnostic and statistical manual of mental disorders* (5th ed.). Arlington, VA: American Psychiatric Publishing.

Appendix

1. How does Christopher Robin's character evolve over the course of the movie? What triggers this change?

2. How are imagination and play used as tools for healing or transformation?

3. What signs of psychological distress or trauma does adult Christopher Robin exhibit in the film?

4. Could Christopher Robin be interpreted as suffering from PTSD or depression? What evidence supports this view?

5. How does the film comment on the pressures of adulthood in contrast to the innocence of childhood?

6. What role does memory (or repression of childhood) play in Christopher Robin's identity and struggles?